for the first time. I went up to Anjali and said to her that we would call our daughter Sara. In fact, it was a name that Ajit had suggested and both Anjali and I loved it. When the doctor asked me to hold Sara, I was much too nervous to do so at first, though I was longing to take her in my arms. I had never held a newborn in my life.

On the day of Sara's birth, I asked permission from the hospital authorities to stay with Anjali in her room. I simply did not want to leave my wife and daughter alone. While I knew that they were in good hands, I wanted to be with them the whole time. They were only too kind and suggested that, while there wasn't an extra bed for me, I could stay in the same room as Anjali and they were happy to provide a mattress, which was placed on the floor. That was fine with me and I will always appreciate their help.

Sara, according to everyone who saw her, was a carbon copy of me and I loved the act of putting her to sleep in my arms. I would just rock her for a couple of minutes and she would go off to sleep. I had a beard then and once she was a few months old I would place her on my lap and brush her hair with it. It was a favourite father–daughter pastime and something both of us loved to do every day.

With a packed cricket calendar, which entailed me being away from home for long periods, it could not have been easy for Anjali to bring up young Sara alone, but not once did she appear to resent this or ask me to spend more time at home. For my part, I know I found it difficult to leave my newborn daughter. Every time I came back after a tour I could spot the changes in her and I was aware that I was missing out on something truly special.

The first international destination that young Sara travelled to was New Zealand in December 1998. We arrived in Napier to start with and the team were given comfortable serviced apartments to stay in. I was given a two-bedroom apartment and it was decided that Anjali and Sara would sleep in one bedroom while I used the other. Sara, who had just turned one, had serious trouble adjusting to the time difference. She would be awake all night and would expect Anjali to play with her the whole time. I would put her to sleep all right, but then she would wake up an hour later and start wandering all over the apartment. Because I had to train or play a match the next day, there was no way I could stay up with her. As a result the responsibility fell on Anjali.